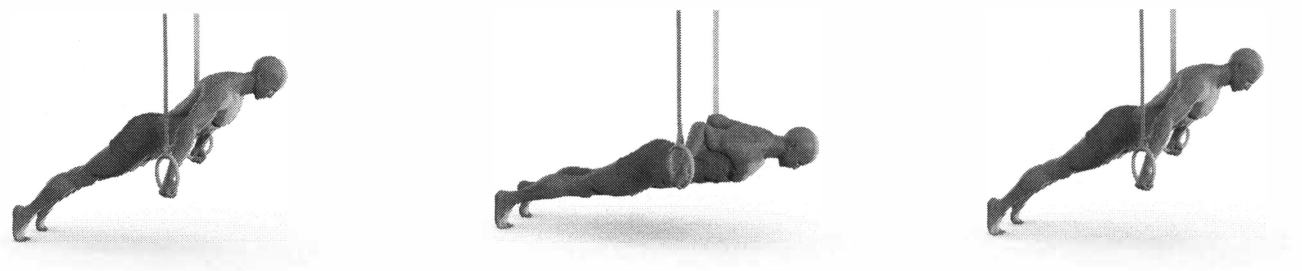


RINGS-TURNED-OUT, 40-DEGREE-LEAN PSEUDO PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 7

Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

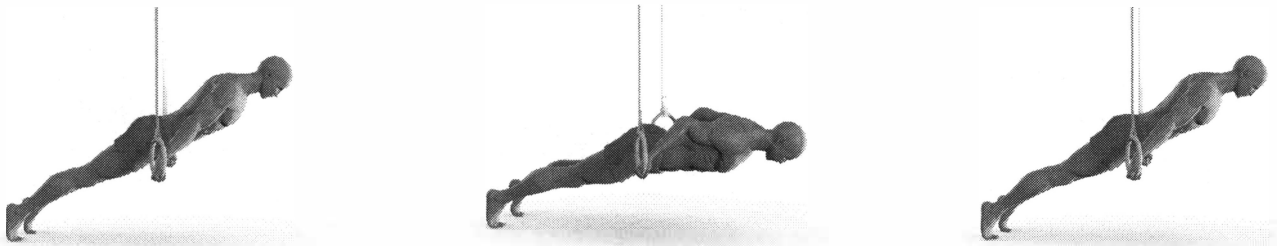
Technique: From the top of the movement, lean forward to obtain a forty-degree angle at your shoulders. The forty-degree lean forward refers to the angle created between an imaginary line running perpendicular to the ground through your hands and the line from your hands to the shoulders. The rings should be turned out. From there, descend into the bottom of the movement (your hands should reach your stomach/waist area) without allowing the rings to turn back in. Pause at the bottom before fully pressing out to the point where your arms reach a forty-degree forward position and are locked. Pause at the top for a few seconds before attempting another repetition.

This skill can be abbreviated *RTO 40 Deg PPPU*. The pseudo planche pushup and maltese variations focus heavily on forward lean (planche position) to decrease leverage. Contrary to popular belief, this requires immense strength in all of the musculature involved in this movement, not just specific muscle groups.

Your body must be locked in a straight or slightly hollow position, with your hips pointed straight down. Any type of pseudo planche pushup is more effective, albeit harder, when your feet are raised to shoulder height. If you have the strength to do this, go for it.

For all of the planche movements, the hardest parts of the movement will be at the ends of the range of motion. It is imperative to hold quality pauses at both the top and bottom of the movement in order to effectively develop the strength needed to move in and out of these positions. Make sure to keep the rings turned out, as well as straight-body positioning for the duration of the skill.

RINGS-TURNED-OUT, 60-DEGREE-LEAN PSEUDO PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 8

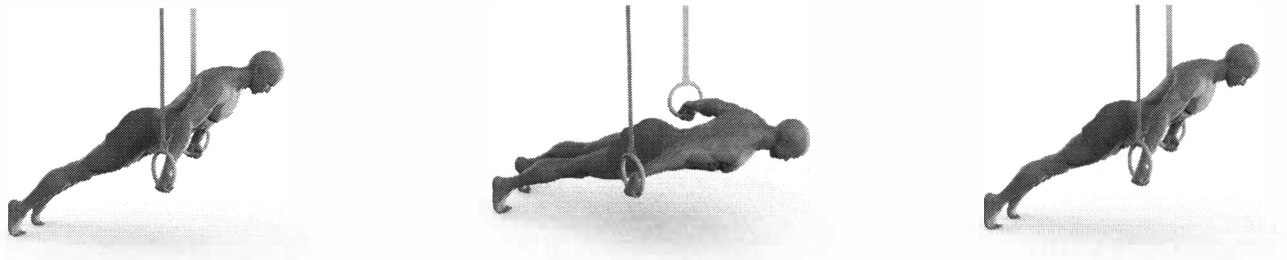


Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: For this movement, you will lean forward to obtain a sixty-degree angle with the rings turned out (see previous exercise for explanation of angle). From there, descend into the bottom of the movement. Your hands should reach your stomach/waist area without allowing the rings to turn back in. Pause at the bottom before fully pressing out to the point where your arms are fully locked. Pause at the top for a few seconds before attempting another repetition.

This skill can be abbreviated *RTO 60 Deg PPPU*. The 60-degree lean forward is very close to the actual planche position, except some of your weight will be on your feet. By performing this exercise regularly, even without specific planche isometric work, it is possible to build up to a good straddle planche on the floor or parallel bars. It will take consistently applied technique over many months or even years. Make sure to keep the rings turned out, as well as straight-body positioning for the duration of the skill.

RINGS-TURNED-OUT MALTESE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 9



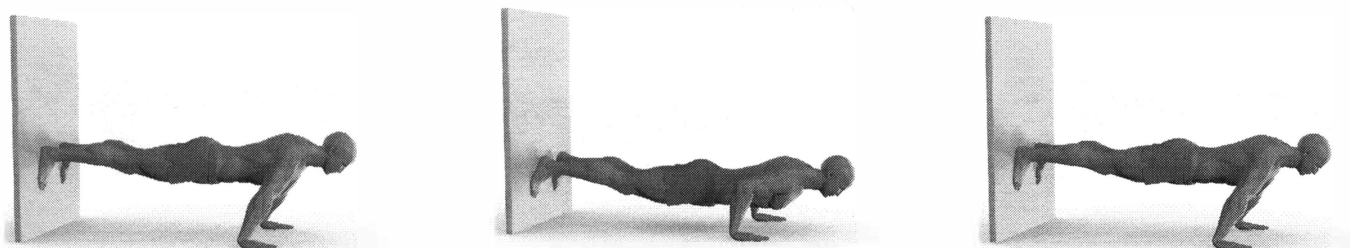
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: Begin with the rings turned out and descend into the bottom of the movement (until your hands become level with your torso) while attempting to bend as little as possible. As you descend, slide the rings out roughly a foot from your sides to create a thirty to forty-five degree angle from your torso to your arms.

This skill can be abbreviated *RTO Maltese PU*. If your strength is lacking, you will have to bend your arms a lot to prevent falling while performing this skill. As you get more proficient, you will not have to bend your arms as much. From the bottom of the movement, push back up into the semi-wide arm planche position.

With *maltese pushups*, slide the rings so that a thirty to forty-five degree angle is created by your armpit and body. This position decreases the leverage of your pectoralis and deltoid muscle groups, which makes the movement much more difficult. Lean your body forward and keep the rings turned out for the duration of the skill. Your body should be kept straight.

WALL PSEUDO PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 10



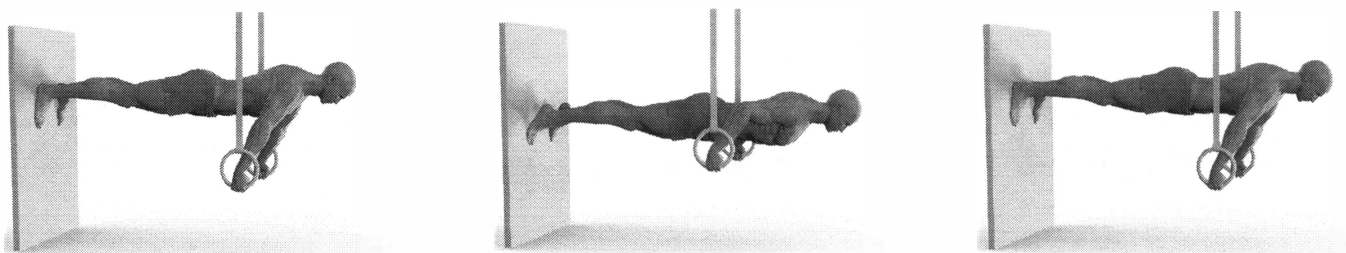
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: You should begin in a proper planche position (straight-body, level at shoulder height) with your feet on the wall and your body leaning forward over your hands. The majority of your support should come from your hands. From there, descend into a pushup. Go all the way to the ground without actually touching it, allowing your feet to slide down the wall. Pause at the bottom of the movement before pushing back to the top. You can slowly walk up the wall with your feet if sliding them back up proves too difficult.

There are many variations of *wall planche pushups* (which can be abbreviated *Wall PPPU*) on the Internet. A few of them are performed correctly. First, let us cover correct technique. If your back is arched at all and/or your hips are allowed to sag, the effectiveness of the exercise is decreased by as much as thirty percent (depending on how much you arch). Since your focus is gaining strength, do not perform this progression unless you can do so with perfect technique. It would be more beneficial to stick to previous progressions that you can perform correctly.

Your primary focus when performing this skill should be on minimizing your amount of foot support and assistance from the wall. In particular, you may want to change your footwear or reduce the wall resistance (if possible) as you get stronger. For example, if your wall is particularly sticky you can invest in smooth plastic or linoleum tiling to make the surface of the wall more slippery. Likewise, you can switch between shoes, bare feet, and socks or other slippery materials to make the movement more difficult.

RINGS WALL PSEUDO PLANCHE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 11



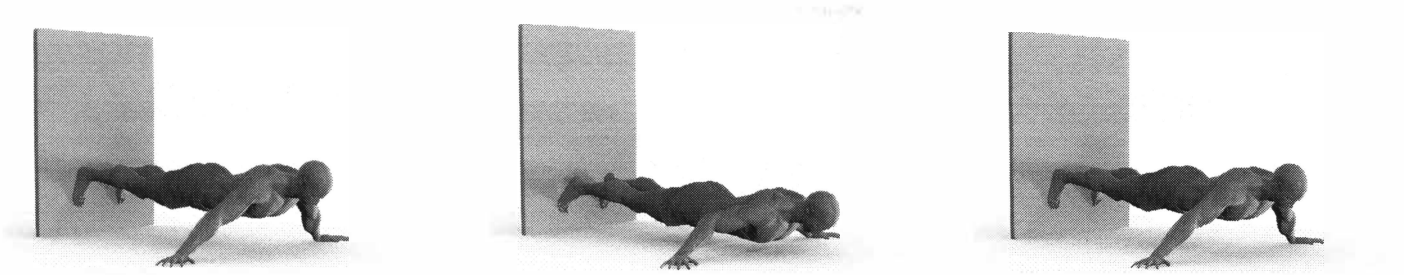
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: This skill is performed with the rings set close to the wall. This allows you to get your feet on the wall in a supported planche position. From there, turn the rings out and stabilize them. Perform a wall planche pushup, maintaining perfect form.

The rings add a significant amount of instability to *wall pseudo planche pushups* (which can be abbreviated *R Wall PPPU*). It should also be noted that the strength of a planche isometric is required to perform this movement correctly. You must keep the rings turned out and maintain straight-body positioning for the duration of the skill. However, when you are first learning this skill you can keep the rings parallel to your body, as shown in the first illustration above. If you do not have access to rings that can be mounted close to a wall, skip this progression as well as the Level 13 progression (rings wall maltese pushups).

Your primary focus should be on minimizing your amount of foot support and assistance from the wall. In particular, you may want to change your footwear or alter the wall resistance (if possible) as you get stronger. For example, if your wall has friction you can invest in smooth plastic or linoleum tiling to make the surface of the wall more slippery. Likewise, you can switch between shoes, bare feet, and socks or other slippery materials to make the movement more difficult.

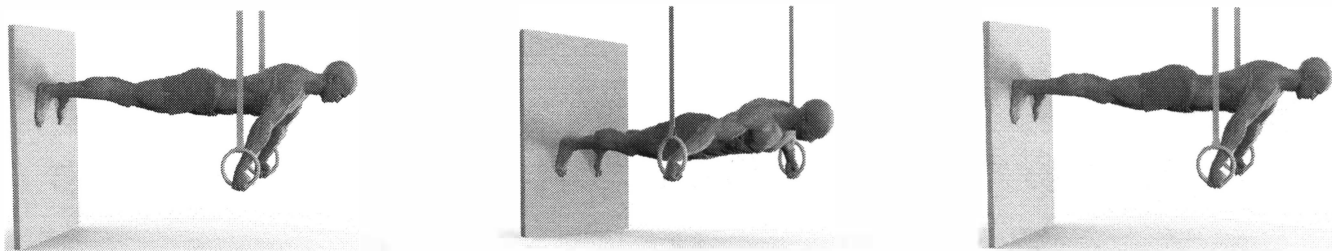
WALL MALTESE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 12



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: *Wall maltese pushups* are performed by moving your hands out from the supported planche position until a thirty to forty-five degree angle is made at the armpit. From there, lower to the ground (without actually touching it) and press back up. Make sure to keep your body straight for the duration of the skill. This will be difficult, as your body will be in a disadvantaged position.

Your primary focus when performing *wall maltese pushups* should be on minimizing the amount of foot support and assistance from the wall. As you get stronger, change your footwear or the wall resistance (if possible) to make the movement more difficult. For example, switch between shoes, bare feet, and socks or other slippery materials, or you can invest in smooth plastic or linoleum tiling to make the surface of the wall more slippery.

RINGS WALL MALTESE PUSHUPS – LEVEL 13

Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: The *rings wall maltese pushup* combines and builds on the previous two skills. It is performed by moving your hands to a thirty to forty-five degree angle in the armpit. Keep the rings turned out, your body straight and perfectly parallel with the ground, and your feet on the wall. From there, bend your arms and lower to the ground without actually touching it before pressing back up. Pause at both the bottom and top of the movement before attempting another repetition.

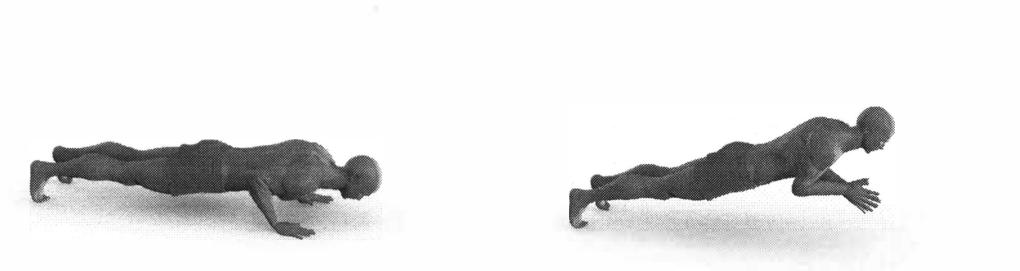
Your primary focus when performing *rings wall maltese pushups* should be on minimizing your amount of foot support and assistance from the wall. As you get stronger, change your footwear or the wall resistance (if possible) to make the movement more difficult. For example, switch between shoes, bare feet, and socks or other slippery materials, or you can invest in smooth plastic or linoleum tiling to make the surface of the wall more slippery.

CLAPPING PUSHUP VARIATIONS – LEVEL N/A

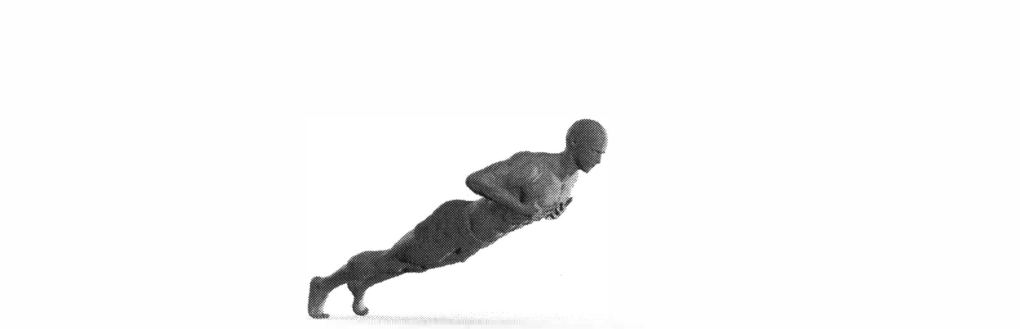
Here are some variations that you can work on if you desire.



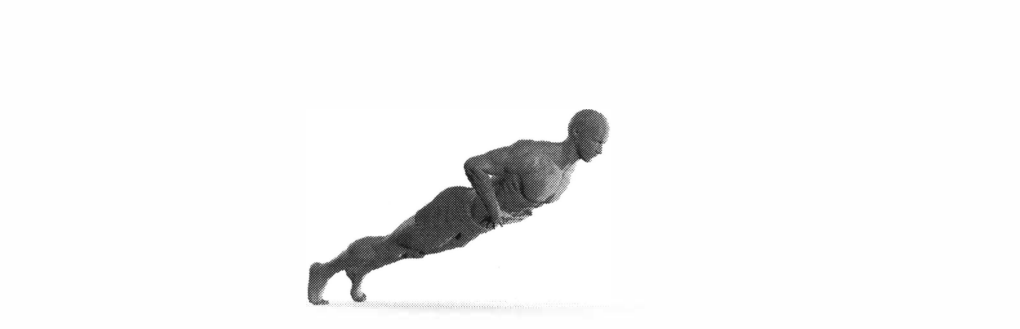
Box (or Stairs) Clapping Pushups



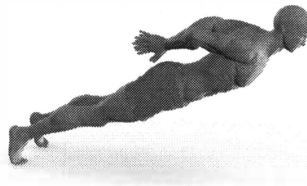
Ground Clapping Pushups



Slap Your Chest



Slap Your Stomach



Behind the Back

The simple variation where you clap your hands in front of your body is not shown in the illustrations above, but it is easier than the variations where you slap your chest or stomach.

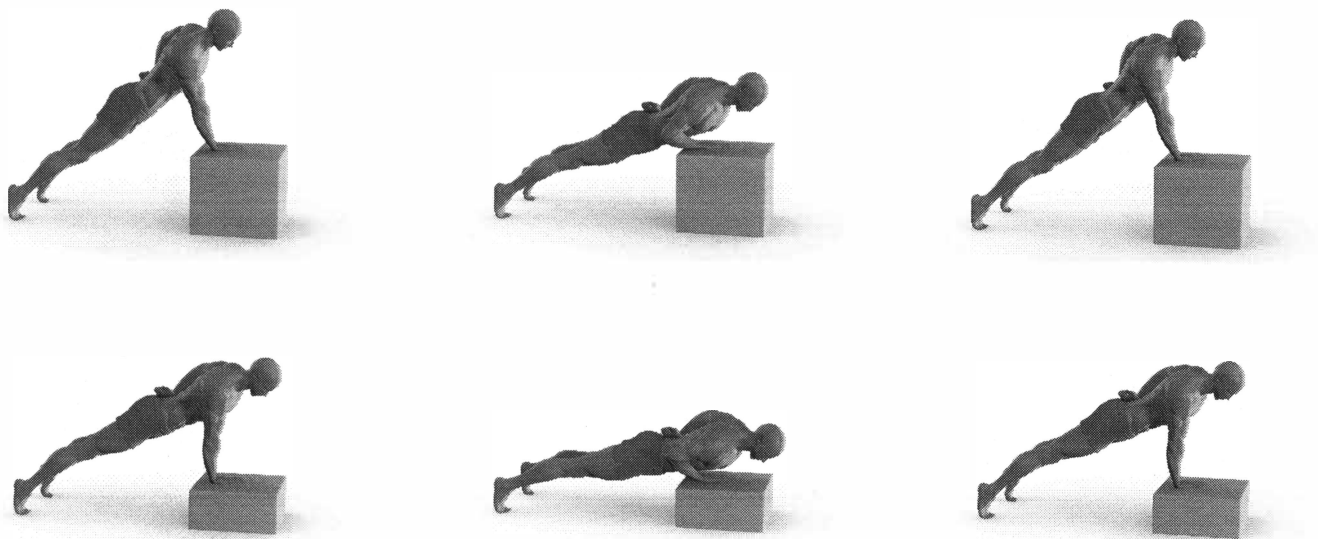
This progression is not as useful as the entire pushup progression, especially when performed on the rings. However, it can be used effectively to gain strength and hypertrophy. One of the cool standards that many individuals desire to work toward is the triple clapping variation:

Pushup to (1) clap in front of your body then (2) clap behind your back then (3) clap in front of your body a second time before returning to the pushup variation.

No one has as yet performed a triple clapping variation cleanly without piking their hips, so it may be more difficult than even Level 10-12 strength. If this is your goal you can work on sequencing the different variations in order to work up to the triple clap variation. Building your own progression will be a good indicator of how much you have learned.

One-Arm Pushups – Page 3, Column 6

HANDS-ELEVATED, ONE-ARM PUSHUP – LEVEL 5



Scapular Positioning: Your scapula will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: Bend one arm and descend into the movement until your chest barely touches the raised surface. Keep your bent arm at roughly a forty-five degree angle with your body as you do this. Press back up to the one-arm support position.

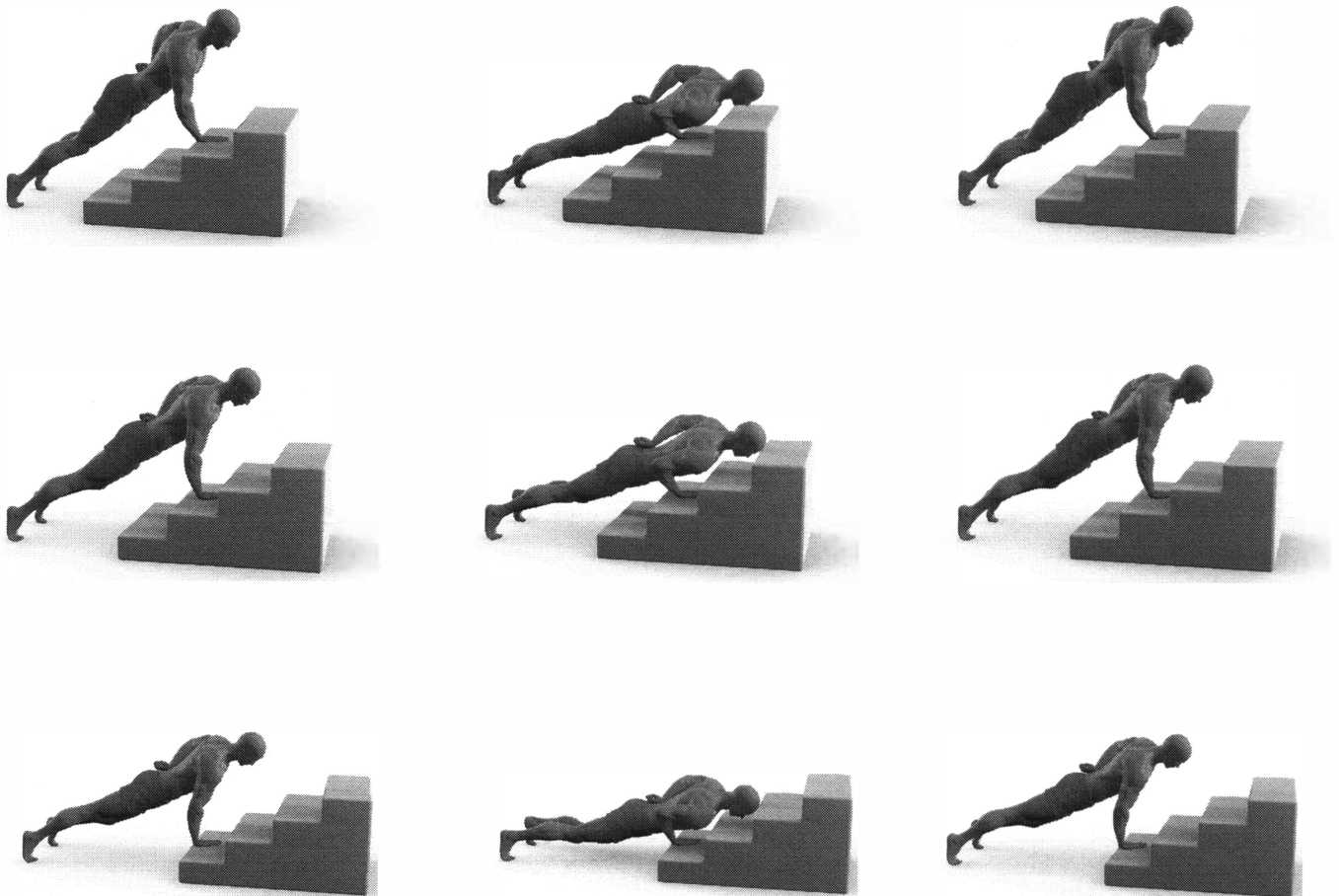
The *hands-elevated, one-arm pushup* (which can be abbreviated *Elevated OA PU*) can be made easier or more difficult by varying the height of the object that your hand is placed on. The key points of technique for this skill include locking your body straight and shifting your weight onto one arm. A straddled leg position may be employed to increase stability.

If your elbow is too far out, the skill will be more difficult to perform due to increased torque. However, increased rotational torque can be used to build core strength. Similarly, having your elbow too close to your body will increase the difficulty of the movement by placing a huge amount of stress on your triceps and shoulders.

Aside from arm angle, other difficulties encountered during this skill are related to the amount of torque on your wrist and possibly your elbows. If the torque at your wrist is an issue, rotate your wrist until you find a better position. If torque at your elbow is an issue, either your shoulder angle is off or you do not have enough elbow strength for this skill. In the event that the latter is true, you can increase the height of the surface to make the skill easier.

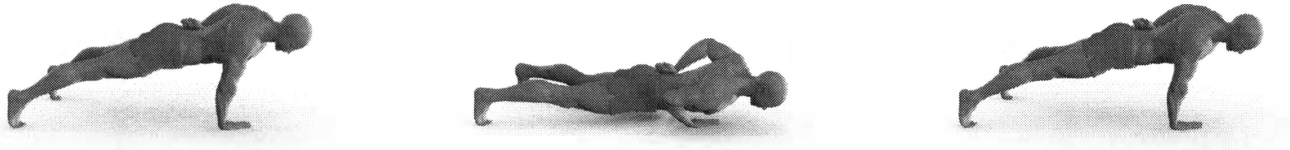
If you are new to this progression, start out with your body at a 45-degree angle with the ground. Progressively decrease the height of the block until you can reach the ground, at which point you will move on to the next progression. Decrease ten to fifteen degrees at a time as you improve.

Be sure to keep your core extremely tight. Take a deep breath and descend while squeezing your abdominals, lower back, hip flexors, glutes, and quads. Focus all of the strength through your shoulder during the movement, keeping the rest of your body still. Beyond that, performing the skill is a matter of strength.



Another alternative is using stairs to progressively decrease to work toward the one-arm pushup, as illustrated above.

STRADDLE ONE-ARM PUSHUP – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: Your scapula will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

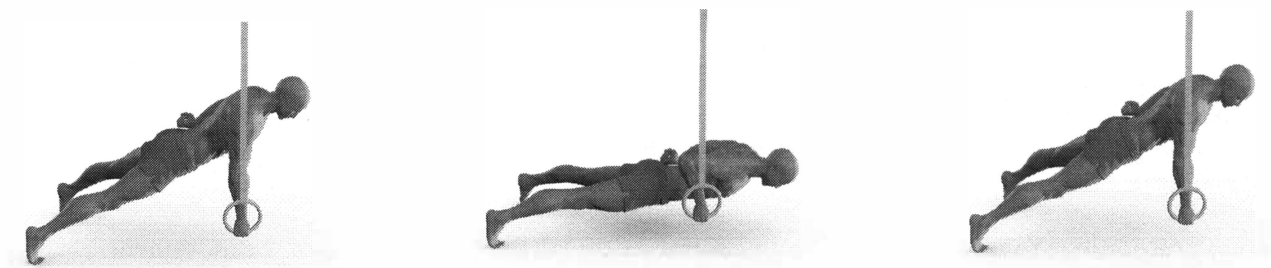
Technique: This one-arm pushup variation is performed on the ground. Descend into the movement until your chest barely touches the ground and then press back up to the starting position. You may straddle your legs as wide as possible at first to make the movement easier, but bring them together as you progress to perform the movement with standard form.

When performing a *straddle one-arm pushup* (which can be abbreviated *Straddle OA PU*), you want your elbow angle to be forty-five degrees (or a bit less) with your armpit in order to help protect your shoulder and avoid excessive torque at any particular joint. Like the previous progression, core tightness is the key to this skill. Do this and the rest of the skill only involves building your strength.

You may also feel some torque during the movement. This will twist your body slightly. Pressure will be placed on your working arm and, typically, your opposite leg. Resist this pressure as much as possible, as the force will encourage your pelvis to twist, making the movement look sloppy.

Your foot receiving the most pressure may be the one that is opposite of your arm that is performing the pushup. While this is natural, you should aim to equalize this pressure.

RINGS STRADDLE ONE-ARM PUSHUP – LEVEL 7



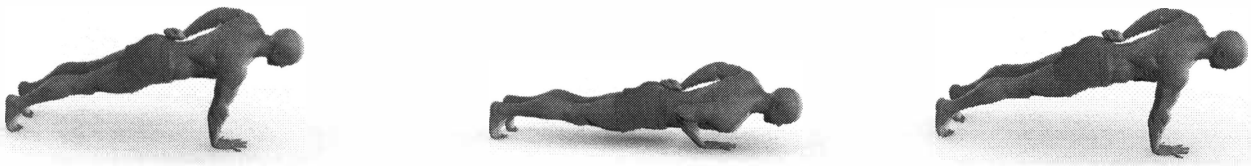
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: First, lower the rings to within two to four inches off the ground. Alternatively, you can elevate your feet off the ground at rings-height. (The former method is safer.) Begin in a straddle pushup position. Descend until your chest reaches the bottom of the rings and press back up to the starting position.

The rings element adds a fair amount of instability to the *straddle one-arm pushup* skill (which can be abbreviated *Rings Straddle OA PU*) but does not make it too terribly difficult. The only real difference between this technique and other straddled one-arm pushups is you want to keep the elbow angle less than forty-five degrees since any sideways displacement from the rings is going to make the movement much harder. Keep your arm as close to your side as possible.

This is a good lead-in to the straight-body one-arm pushup, which requires your arm to be very close to your side, as there is no laterally displaced foot to help you keep your balance. This exercise will improve your triceps and shoulder strength immensely.

STRAIGHT-BODY, ONE-ARM PUSHUP – LEVEL 8

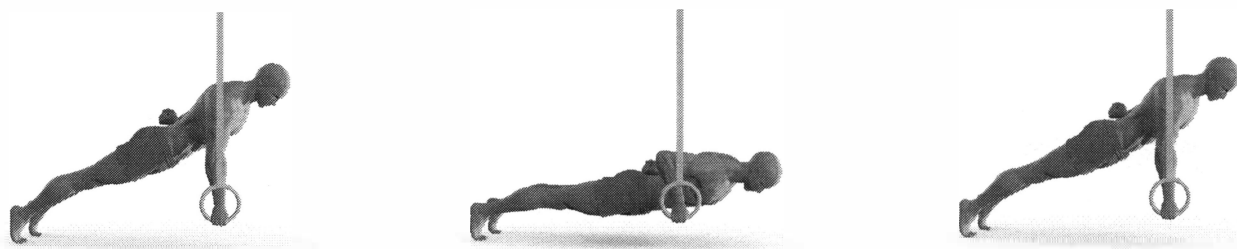


Scapular Positioning: Your scapula will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: The technique is the same as the previous skill, except your feet are held together, your elbow is in, close to your body and chest, and your core is kept tight. Begin in the one-arm straight-body pushup position. Descend until your chest lightly brushes the ground and press back up to the full one-arm pushup starting position.

The *straight-body, one-arm pushup* (which can be abbreviated *Straight-Body OA PU*) is a feat very few are able to master. This skill requires a very good sense of balance and an extraordinary level of strength in your shoulder girdle and elbows.

The balance component is the most difficult to master: The best advice is to lean toward the arm that is doing the pushup, and learn how to shift your weight from side to side in the descent. There are small corrections that need to be implemented during the descent and ascent, so it may take a bit of practice to get the feel of the balance before you can perform this skill efficiently.

RINGS STRAIGHT-BODY, ONE-ARM PUSHUP – LEVEL 9

Scapular Positioning: Your scapula will be fully protracted and depressed at the top of the movement. During the motion, your scapulas will naturally retract. They will be almost fully retracted at the bottom. As you move back to the starting position, you will finish with your scapulas fully protracted and depressed.

Technique: Lower the rings to within two to four inches off the ground. Alternatively, you can elevate your feet off the ground at rings-height. (The former method is safer.) Begin in a straight-body, one-arm pushup position. Descend until your chest lightly brushes the ground and press back up to the full one-arm pushup starting position.

Taking the *straight-body, one-arm pushup* to the rings (which can be abbreviated *Rings SB OA PU*) is an impressive feat, as it requires both immense upper-body and core strength. Like the two previous progressions, you want to first solidly lock down your core. Keep your elbow tucked while lowering through the movement and then push out forcefully while keeping your body sturdy. Leaning your body on the strap a bit may help initially but avoid this in the long run.

This technique blasts your core due to the instability of the rings and torsion of only using one arm, similar to the rings straddle one-arm pushup. If your body begins to twist, try to keep the rotation to a minimum because it makes the skill easier.

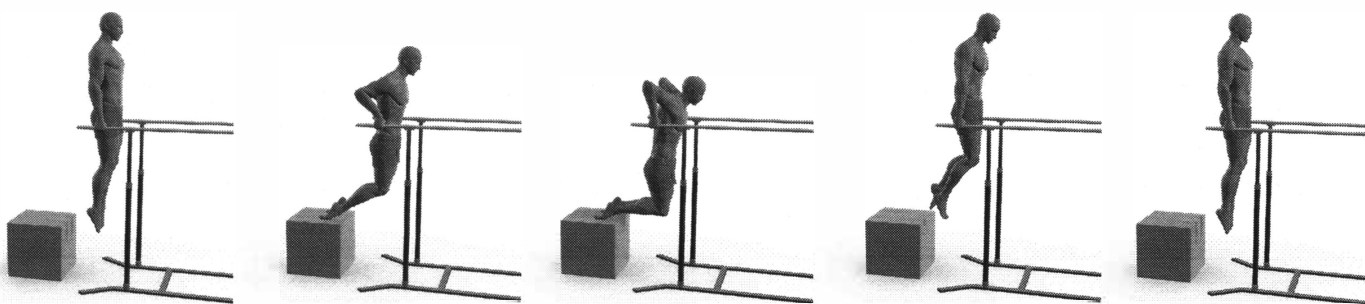
Congratulations on mastering the one-arm pushup progression! At this point, you can add weight to the movements to make them more challenging and continue to work them.

Dips – Page 3, Column 7

The basic dip progression on the parallel bars is short, and most of the skills are geared toward beginners. There are some difficult variations beyond leaned forward dips, but only one-arm dips are included here. (Rings are preferred to build dipping strength.)

The rings add extremely good strength benefits to regular dips. Additionally, they will help you master many of the upper-level progressions in other categories—including the planche. Move away from parallel bar dips and take them to the rings. One exception would be weighted dips, which can still be beneficial.

PARALLEL BAR JUMPING DIPS – LEVEL 1



Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas depressed and neutral. As you lower into the movement, keep them depressed. At the bottom, you will have the choice to relax your scapulas or allow them to be elevated. Whichever you choose, they should be depressed again before you move back to the top of the movement.

Technique: You can either set a block lower so you can squat jump at the bottom of the movement, or you can use your legs to provide assistance. Whichever you choose, begin in the support position and slowly lower to the bottom of the dip before using your legs to jump back to the support position. Try to push through your hands and triceps, using your legs for as little assistance as possible.

Make sure that you go through the full range of motion. This means starting from the support position with your shoulders pushed down (i.e. not shrugged up toward your ears). Lower down into the bottom position of the movement with your hands as far into your armpits as flexibility allows. Then use your legs to help assist your body back to the top position of the movement.

It is common to feel tight in your chest and lats, to the point of feeling a stretch. Use your legs to mitigate the stretch if it is too uncomfortable, but try to sink deep into the stretch in order to help loosen up your shoulders. This flexibility will be put to use much later with muscle-ups, so it is imperative to begin developing it now. If you experience pain and continued aggravation, put this skill on the shelf and consult the Costochondritis section found in Common Bodyweight Injuries chapter. Focus on improving your shoulder mobility so you can perform this skill pain-free.

Alternatively, you can use a Gravitron machine at the gym to help build up to an unassisted concentric dip. This applies for both this progression and the next.

PARALLEL BAR DIP ECCENTRICS – LEVEL 2

Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas depressed and neutral. As you lower into the movement, keep them depressed. At the bottom, you will have the choice to relax your scapulas or allow them to be elevated. Whichever you choose, they should be depressed again before you move back to the top of the movement.

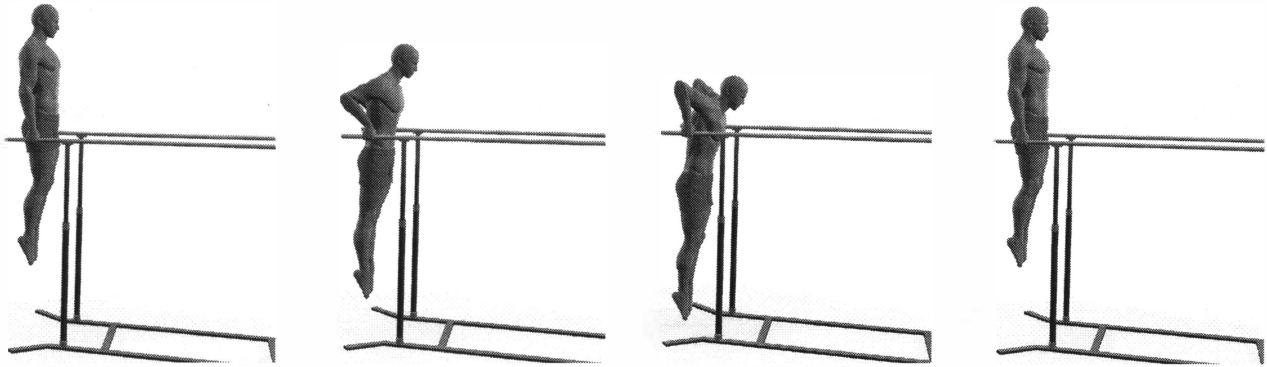
Technique: Begin in the support position and slowly lower to the bottom of the dip position.

A *parallel bar dip eccentric* involves performing only the negative portion of this movement; from the top support position down to the bottom (where your hands are next to the armpits). The goal is to take six to eight seconds to perform a single repetition—working up to seven to ten seconds—and perform two to three full sets containing two to three repetitions per set. This gives you enough time under eccentric control to build the strength and muscle mass required to obtain a full range of motion dip.

The key with this skill is to lower uniformly. If you lower too slowly in the first portion of the movement, it consumes too much energy, which causes you to pass through the ending portion of the movement far too quickly and with poor form. Correct this now by lowering uniformly and you will reap the benefits later on. If you experience pain, put this skill on the shelf and focus on improving your shoulder mobility so you can perform this exercise pain-free.

Alternatively, you can use a Gravitron machine at the gym to help build up to an unassisted concentric dip. This applies for both this progression and the previous one.

PARALLEL BAR DIPS – LEVEL 3



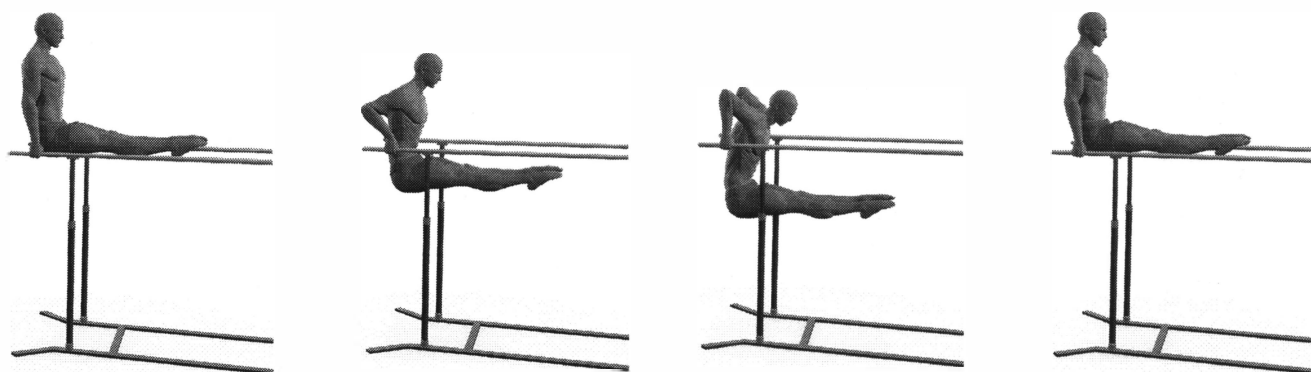
Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas depressed and neutral. As you lower into the movement, keep them depressed. At the bottom, you will have the choice to relax your scapulas or allow them to be elevated. Whichever you choose, they should be depressed again before you move back to the top of the movement. Once you can perform five to ten full range of motion dips without relaxing your scapulas, you will have enough strength for a muscle-up but it may take some time to master the technique.

Technique: Begin in the support position and slowly lower to the bottom of the dip position. Push through your hands and triceps to ascend back to the starting position.

Parallel bar dips are one of the staples of gymnastics strength and conditioning. The technique is similar to the previous progression, except you receive no assistance from your lower body. While performing this skill, keep your body straight and your core tight—in a support position with your shoulder girdle depressed. Lower yourself to the bottom of the movement so that your hands reach your armpits (or your current flexibility limits) and then push back up to the top of the movement.

Head positioning is not critical, but try not to arch or crane your head up while pushing out of dips. This may lead to tightness and pain behind your neck, as well as tension headaches. If you experience pain, put this skill on the shelf and focus on improving your shoulder mobility so you can perform this exercise pain-free.

L-SIT DIPS – LEVEL 4



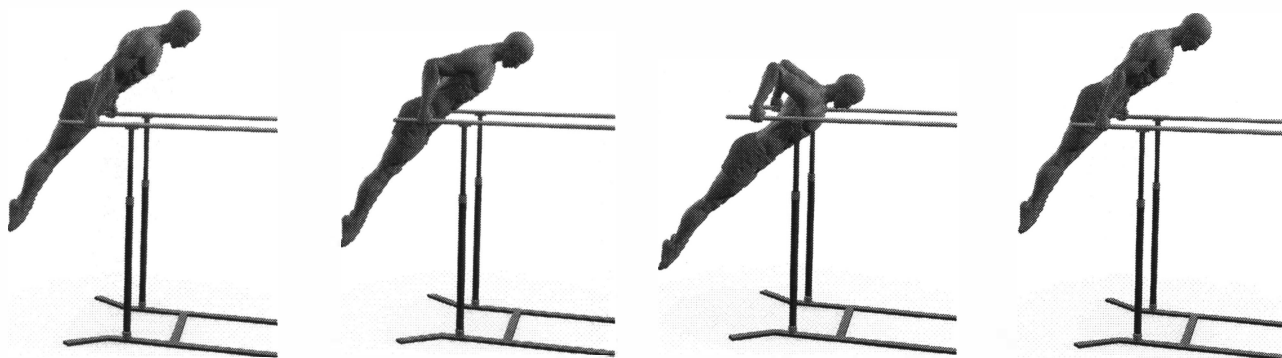
Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas depressed and neutral. As you descend into the movement, keep them depressed. At the bottom, you will have the choice to relax your scapulas or allow them to be elevated. Whichever you choose, they should be depressed again before you move back to the top of the movement.

Technique: Begin in the L-sit support position. Slowly lower to the bottom of the L-sit dip position. Push through your hands and triceps to ascend back to the L-sit support position. Make sure you do not allow your legs to drop during any part of the movement. Your elbows may flare out slightly.

L-sit dips decrease the leverage of your triceps and shoulders by pushing your center of mass backward four to six inches, just like *L-sit pull-ups*. This will make the L-sit dip more difficult since there is a mechanical disadvantage when you increase tension on your triceps and shoulders. Expect a further challenge to stabilize through the depth of the movement due to the increased balance component.

It is important to maintain the L-sit position by keeping your legs parallel to the ground. It is equally important to descend as deeply into the dip as possible to get the full benefits of this strength move. This will also set you up for smooth muscle-ups when you reach that progression. Your range of motion for this skill may be limited when you begin training due to the balance component. This will be remedied as you grow stronger with consistent practice.

45-DEGREE FORWARD-LEAN DIPS – LEVEL 5



Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas depressed and neutral. As you descend into the movement, keep them depressed. At the bottom, you will have the choice to relax your scapulas or allow them to be elevated. Whichever you choose, they should be depressed again before you move back to the top of the movement.

Technique: Begin in the support position and lean forward so that your body reaches a forty-five degree angle. Descend, maintaining this forty-five degree angle, until you reach the bottom of the dip and press back up through your hands and shoulders.

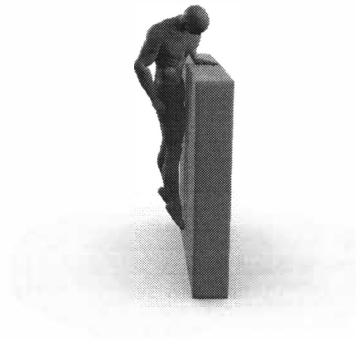
Leaning forward during dips, along with the planche variations, is one way to increase the challenge level of a basic skill. These variations require more body control, which puts the responsibility for advancement on the trainee. This is preferred to other methods of making dips more difficult.

It is your responsibility to ensure that you keep your body perfectly straight or in a slightly hollow position for the duration of the movement. Arching occurs naturally, but it must be resisted because it makes the skill easier. Dipping with a 45-degree forward lean can be accomplished two ways, the first of which is easier than the second:

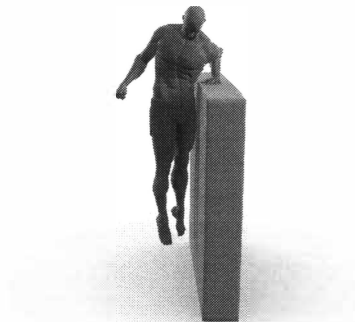
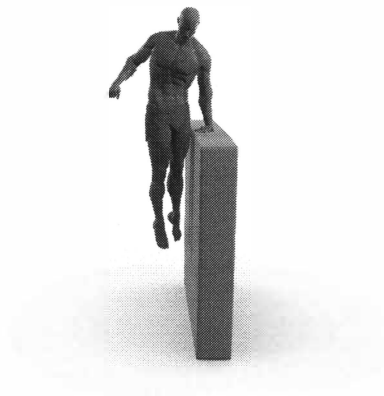
- Begin in a standard vertical support position. Lean forward as you enter the dip. Your lean will increase throughout the motion, meeting a 45-degree angle by the time you reach the bottom of the movement. From there, push back to support position.
- Begin in a 45-degree forward lean and maintain that position for the duration of the movement.

The hardest parts of this skill are pushing out of the bottom of the movement and locking out at the top if you use the second method. Avoid the inclination to arch at these points.

ONE-ARM DIP – LEVELS 8 & 9



Facing the Wall



Parallel to the Wall



A method that makes the skill exercise easier by bending your torso over a wall.

Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas depressed and neutral. As you descend into the movement, keep them depressed. They will naturally retract during the movement, which is fine. After you hit the bottom, they will naturally return to a neutral position as you ascend.

Technique: There are two different variations of the one-arm dip, and a way to make each more difficult. These progressions should be performed on a wall, used to brace your legs for balance. It is possible to use a single rail, but it will make the skill significantly harder. Descending and ascending is the same as in the straight-body, one-arm pushup progressions. Keep your arm tucked in close to your body in order to minimize torque at your joints and rotational forces. Your core and legs must also be squeezed tight.

- The first variation of the *one-arm dip* is performed with your body facing a wall. You will typically place your hand toward the middle of your body with your fingers pointing forward.
- The second variation is performed by standing parallel to the wall, with one side of your body next to the wall. In this position, you place your hand in line with the direction you are facing. There will be some lean over your arm to maintain balance.

Like the one-arm chin-up or one-arm pushup, this progression can be useful for assessing your unilateral strength balance. It also requires good use of your core stabilizers. Plus, it is fun to see if you can perform this type of skill.

This skill can be made easier by simply bending your torso down and up. This decreases any movement of your legs, which takes weight off your pushing arm. Additionally, your legs can be used for minimal pushing because the wall generates a bit of friction. You will ultimately want to eliminate any forms of assistance by performing this skill with a straight body while only pressing through one arm.

If you bend and/or twist your torso as illustrated above, it can make the skill much easier—to the point where the skill level drops to Level 6 or 7. This can be used as a method to work up to the full skill, and it is also an alternative movement you can use to work on strength in the absence of a weighted vest, weight belt, parallettes, or other equipment.

Rings Dips – Page 3, Column 8

Rings dips are critical for building upper-body strength. Like the other progressions, these types of dips put the responsibility for correct execution on the trainee. Keep your body in the hollow position and commit yourself to resisting the inclination to arch.

SUPPORT HOLD – LEVEL 1



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be depressed and neutral. It is very easy to protract them, thus caving in your chest. This should be avoided.

Technique: Lock your arms so they are straight and in the rings support position. In this position, with your arms locked straight, depress the shoulder girdle (shoulders away from the ears). If you are a true beginner, to make the movement simpler, focus on gluing the rings to your sides to stabilize the position. If you are having difficulty with this movement, work it on parallel bars or parallettes first and then transition over to rings.

Your goal is to be able to hold the rings a couple of inches away from the side of your body. To increase the difficulty of the skill, you can start to point your palms forward to attain the rings-turned-out position.

Make sure to remember to breathe. Attempt to build up each hold to thirty seconds before increasing the difficulty of the skill. Focus on maintaining proper body positions, as this will help you significantly in the future. This skill is a great warm-up, especially for beginners.

RINGS-TURNED-OUT SUPPORT HOLD – LEVEL 2



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be depressed and neutral. It is very easy to protract them, which allows your chest to cave. This should be avoided.

Technique: Lock your arms so they are straight and in the rings support position. Slowly turn your palms to facing forward.

For the vast majority of rings support positions, you will begin with your hands turned in. Eventually, you want to be able to begin with your forearms and palms facing your body and the rings parallel to each other. Once you become proficient in this skill, turn the rings so your palms face forward. The zero to ninety degrees of the rings-turned-out (RTO) movement ranges:

- 0-degree position, rings stay parallel with each other, palms face you.
- 90-degree position, rings form a straight line through your body, palms face directly forward.

The RTO position is essential for developing many high-level strength skills, and it will eventually give you a lot more balance and stability even though it may not feel that way when you first begin.

The RTO position helps strengthen your elbows and shoulder connective tissues and it provides a straight-arm strength stimulus for your biceps. This will pay dividends in the future as you work up to more advanced rings movements.

The key concept for this position is palms forward. This rotates the inside of your elbows forward, and rotates your shoulder into external rotation. Physiologically, elbows-pointing-forward is the most stable position. By turning out your palms, the head of your humerus is centered in your glenohumeral joint, which puts your rotator cuff muscles in a good position to stabilize the joint.

RINGS DIP ECCENTRICS – LEVEL 3

Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be depressed and neutral. It is very easy to protract them, which allows your chest to cave. This should be avoided. As you descend into the movement, keep your scapulas depressed and neutral until you reach the bottom. Once there, you may relax your scapulas and allow them to elevate.

Technique: Lock your arms so they are straight and in the rings support position. Slowly lower from the support position to the bottom of the dip.

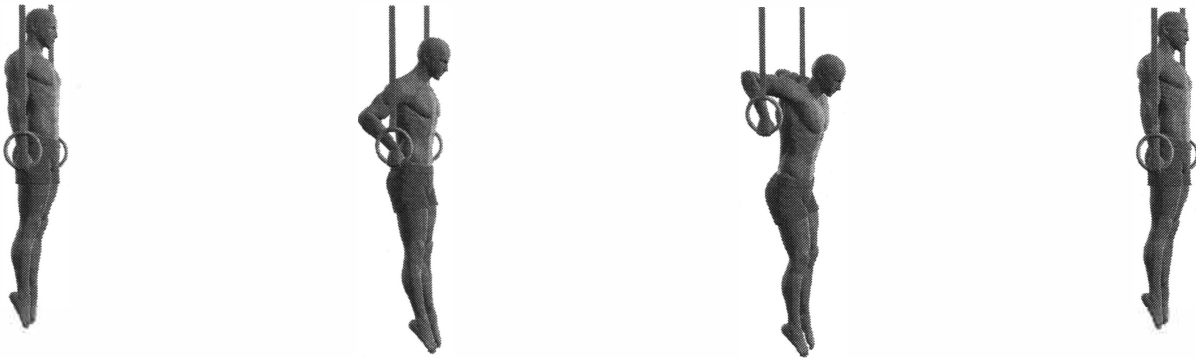
Rings dip eccentrics are the same as the bar eccentrics. The goal is to take six to ten seconds per single repetition and perform two to three full sets of two to three repetitions per set. Sets at this length will build the strength and muscle mass needed to obtain a full range of motion dip.

The key here is to lower uniformly. It is a common mistake, especially at first, to lower too slowly in the beginning portion of the movement. This uses up all your energy, causing you to pass through the end of the movement far too quickly and with poor execution.

The rings are easily stabilized by pressing them to your sides to prevent them from wobbling, especially during the lowering phase. During the ascent your arms will attempt to move away from your body. Keep them glued to your side.

If you are having difficulty, additional support hold work may be needed. Work your way up to a sixty-second support hold, then work it in the RTO position.

RINGS DIPS – LEVEL 4



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be depressed and neutral. It is very easy to protract them, but that allows your chest to cave. This should be avoided. As you descend into the movement, keep your scapulas depressed and neutral until you reach the bottom. Once there, you may relax your scapulas and allow them to elevate.

Technique: Begin with the rings turned out (or at least parallel) in the support position. As you descend into the dip, you can allow your hands to rotate in if you desire. Your hands must remain close to your body, if not tight, for stability purposes. Pause in the bottom of the movement and push out to the top.

The instability of the rings provides greater strength increases than solely working the parallel bar dip progression. At this stage, you do not have to turn the rings out to perform *rings dips*. Work the support position with the rings turned out as soon as possible, but it is not necessary to hold the RTO position for the entire movement.

The key for this skill is to keep your hands glued to your sides and drive force through the base of your palms. It may help to focus on squeezing your chest and lats tight to your body as a cue.

RINGS L-SIT DIPS – LEVEL 5

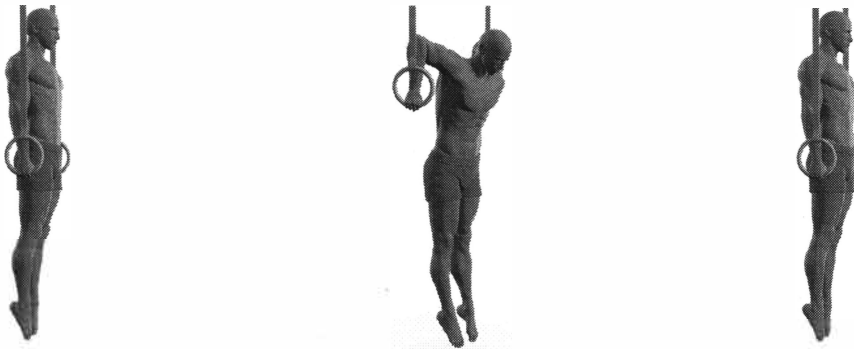
Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be depressed and neutral. It is very easy to protract them, but that allows your chest to cave. This should be avoided. As you descend into the movement, keep your scapulas depressed and neutral until you reach the bottom. Once there, you may relax your scapulas and allow them to elevate.

Technique: Begin in an L-sit position (with the rings turned out or at parallel) and lower into the movement while keeping your legs parallel with the ground. Go as far down as possible before pushing back up, keeping your legs level. Remember to keep the rings glued to your sides for the duration of the movement. Pause at the bottom of the movement before pushing back to the top.

Rings L-sit dips, like the parallel bar variation, focus on developing triceps strength and stabilization when the rings are in front of your body. This strength is useful for future progressions where you maintain your hands in front of your body, such as L-cross and front lever progressions.

It is a common mistake to allow your legs to dip. You should keep them at 90-degrees or higher for the duration of the movement. This fault will usually manifest when you push out of the bottom of the dip. You may want to keep your hands slightly in front of you in order to counteract the forces that make your legs dip.

RINGS WIDE DIPS – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be depressed and neutral. It is very easy to protract them, but that allows your chest to cave. This should be avoided. As you descend into the movement, keep your scapulas depressed and neutral until you reach the bottom. Once there, you may relax your scapulas and allow them to elevate.

Technique: There are two variations of *rings wide dips*:

- One variation is performed by beginning in the rings-turned-out (RTO) position. From there, allow your arms to go wide. Simultaneously allow your hands to rotate so your palms face backward. Finish the movement by performing the reverse motion, ending in a rings-turned-out support position. This variation internally rotates your shoulder, which places more stress on your lats and chest. It is useful for prepping your shoulders for more advanced moves like the iron cross.
- The other variation can be performed by simply pushing the rings out six to twelve inches from your body and holding this position while performing the dips. Like the other variation, this motion is hard on your shoulders and has an increased stability factor.

Work one or the other (or both), but know that this is just a progression to pass through.

RINGS-TURNED-OUT 45 DEGREES PAST PARALLEL DIPS – LEVEL 7**RINGS-TURNED-OUT 75 DEGREES PAST PARALLEL DIPS – LEVEL 8****RINGS-TURNED-OUT 90 DEGREES PAST PARALLEL DIPS – LEVEL 9**

Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be depressed and neutral. It is very easy to protract them, but that allows your chest to cave. This should be avoided. As you descend into the movement, keep your scapulas depressed and neutral until you reach the bottom. Once there, you may relax your scapulas and allow them to elevate. Depress them again as you move out of the bottom back to the top position.

Technique: Begin in the support position, with the rings turned out. Lower in a controlled manner to the bottom of the dip while keeping your body straight. Do not allow your wrists to bend. Press out of the bottom of the dip to the rings-turned-out support position. Keep the rings turned out at the same angle for the duration of the movement.

These skills can be abbreviated *RTO 45 Deg Dips*, *RTO 75 Deg Dips*, and *RTO 90 Deg Dips*, respectively. The more you turn the rings out past the parallel position, the more difficult the skill. As noted previously, turning the rings out decreases the inherent stability of the rings themselves, forcing you to stabilize them via muscular coordination. Once the rings are turned out, they should never be turned back in for the duration of the movement. The last progression illustrated above shows the rings turned out to ninety degrees past parallel and held that way for the duration of the movement.

This skill is executed the same as the rest of the dipping movements. Do not forget to keep your hands glued to your sides! Concentrating on limiting instability more than the dipping motion itself should make the technique easier. When the rings are turned out this far, you will have to fight to keep them from turning back in at the top and bottom of the movement, especially during the concentric phase. You can do this by locking your forearms in a supinated position.

As you may have noticed, many of the RTO positions not only tax your stabilizers (in this case, your chest and lats) they also thoroughly work your arms, especially your biceps and its tendons. This is the primary reason for implementing the RTO dip skills at this point in your training. This increase in dip difficulty prepares your elbows for higher-level rings skills like crosses and one-arm chin-ups.

RINGS-TURNED-OUT 90 DEGREES + 30-DEGREE FORWARD-LEAN DIPS – LEVEL 10

RINGS-TURNED-OUT 90 DEGREES + 50-DEGREE FORWARD-LEAN DIPS – LEVEL 11

RINGS-TURNED-OUT 90 DEGREES + 65-DEGREE FORWARD-LEAN DIPS – LEVEL 12

RINGS-TURNED-OUT 90 DEGREES + 75-DEGREE FORWARD-LEAN DIPS – LEVEL 13

RINGS-TURNED-OUT 90 DEGREES + 82-DEGREE FORWARD-LEAN DIPS – LEVEL 14

RINGS-TURNED-OUT 90 DEGREES + 86-DEGREE FORWARD-LEAN DIPS – LEVEL 15

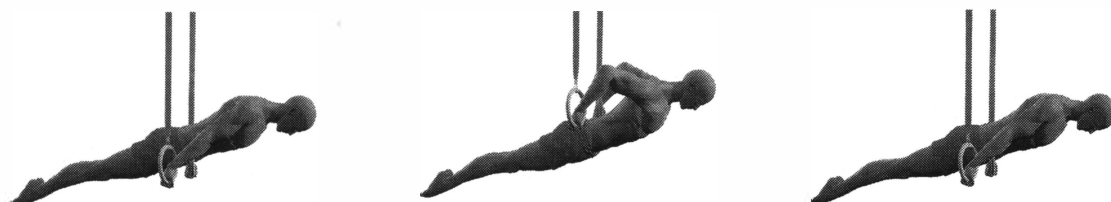
RINGS-TURNED-OUT 90 DEGREES + 88-DEGREE FORWARD-LEAN DIPS – LEVEL 16



30-Degree Forward Lean



50-Degree Forward Lean



75-Degree Forward Lean

Scapular Positioning: Your scapulas should be depressed and neutral. It is very easy to protract them, thus caving in your chest. This should be avoided. As you descend into the movement, keep your scapulas depressed and neutral until you reach the bottom. Once there, you may relax your scapulas and allow them to elevate. Depress them again as you move out of the bottom back to the top position.

Technique: Begin in the support position, with the rings turned out. Lean forward to the appropriate angle and lower in a controlled manner to the bottom of the dip. Keep your body straight and do not allow your wrists to bend. Press out of the bottom of the dip to the starting position, maintaining the lean in your body. Keep the rings turned out at the same angle for the duration of the movement.

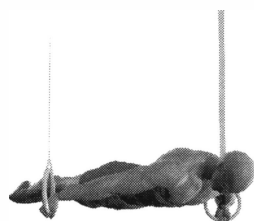
These skills can be abbreviated *RTO 90 + 30 Dips*, *RTO 90 + 50 Dips*, *RTO 90 + 65 Dips*, and *RTO 90 + 75 Dips*, respectively. Leaning forward will build on the control and connective tissue strength that you have already established from the previous RTO dip progressions. The forward lean puts more stress on all of your anterior muscle groups. Although the total range of motion will decrease, the torque will increase. RTO forward-lean dips act like a hybrid version of planche pushups and a leaning maltese progression. They make for excellent work in progressing toward those skills.

Keep a straight or slightly hollow body position. Your body will want to arch heavily, particularly at your abdominal region. This should be avoided because it makes the exercise significantly easier.

The forward lean portion of the skill (at the beginning and end—with straight arms) is very important. While some coaches may not like combining a forward lean with dips, as long as proper form is maintained the combination can build excellent control that can be utilized for moving in and out of other positions. Try pausing/holding for two seconds if you are working toward the maltese.

As you progress in strength, the angle you are able to obtain per level will diminish (similar to the cross). It is not uncommon for people with Level 8 strength to be able to lean forward forty-five degrees and hold this position for a few seconds. This may give you the illusion that you are more than halfway to the maltese. In reality, you are probably only one-fourth of the way there, due to increases in torque and decreases in muscle leverage.

MALTESE HOLD – LEVEL 17



Multiple gymnasts have utilized this forward-lean progression to obtain their maltese holds. It is obtainable with only the forward-lean progression absent of dips. Likewise, you can work solely planche leans to obtain the planche. Here, dips are combined with the forward lean because, like pseudo planche pushups, it builds bent-arm and straight-arm strength into one progression. Feel free to use the leaned forward progression alone or in conjunction with dips to work toward the maltese.

Weighted Dips – Page 3, Column 9

Weighted dips are often called “the squat of the upper body” due to the amount of musculature they use. They can be performed on either parallel bars or rings. Rings weighted dips are going to be more difficult than those performed on parallel bars at lower levels. However, once you begin to move toward full 2x bodyweight dips, they actually are easier on rings. While the rings tend to splay outward, physics dictates that the rings will stay put when you add significant amounts of weight to your body. When the rings move out, they also move up. Therefore, gravity, your bodyweight, and additional weight counteract the outward force that is applied to the rings from your hands. This helps to further stabilize the rings.

The weighted dip progression is very easy to measure, which is why it is particularly useful in training. Weighted dips transfer very well to planche skills, although they do not benefit handstand pushups as much. This should be expected, as weighted dips work the extended range of motion of the shoulder, conferring some benefit to the flexion of the planche. However, it is unlikely to confer benefits to fully flexed shoulder positions like handstands and handstand pushups.

Weighted dips will typically outpace weighted pull-ups by a progression or two due to additional involved musculature. Additionally, your triceps are larger and stronger than your biceps. You should be able to perform a 2x bodyweight dip by the time you reach Level 9. This is consistent with the other skills you will develop around that level. As a point of reference, the straddle planche is a Level 8 skill, and the Half Layout / One-Leg-Out planche is a Level 9 skill.

